2021) was illegal. How can the government issue orders when the gram sabha has ruled out land grabbing?"

As per the Right to Fair Compensation and Transparency in Land Acquisition, Rehabilitation and Resettlement (FCTLARR) Act, 2013, it is mandatory to take the consent of 80 per cent of landowners for private projects and 70 per cent for projects under public-private partnership through resolutions passed by gram sabhas. The land acquisition authority, that is the Odisha government, ignored the sabhas' unanimous resolutions.

Hiramani Minj, a panchayat member, says that despite sitting on a dharna last December and giving a memorandum to the governor, no action was taken. Instead, there is talk of adivasis being wooed with a compensation package of Rs 25 lakh for every acre, besides promises of jobs for a member of each family. But most of them remain unconvinced.

THE ADIVASIS ARE NOT CONVINCED BY PROMISES OF JOBS AND GENEROUS COMPENSATION

Prem Toppo, another farmer, says that he had been a victim of false promises in 1981, when land was bought for a mining and cement factory, and he was given only a paltry compensation. Adds fellow farmer Dilip Toppo, "The assurance of jobs is bogus too. Last time I had to run from pillar to post to manage one and the salary could hardly feed a family of four."

Social activist Madhusudan, who is the president of Jan Jagran Abhiyan, says the participation of women in such large numbers is amazing. "They are fighting for their identity, culture, language and for their future generations—all tied to their land. They cannot be bought," he says.

Bibol Toppo, gram sabha president, and Mahima Toppo, Ajit Lakra and Lalit Lakra, other members, make it clear that their movement will continue till they get a definite assurance from the government that it will relinquish plans for acquisition. As it is, the Fifth Schedule of the Constitution bars the transfer, sale, lease or mortgage of tribal land. The women protesters want to reach out to President Droupadi Murmu, a daughter of the soil, and are hopeful that she'll lend them an ear. ■

KARNATAKA

WALKING THE EXTRA MILE

By Ajay Sukumaran

Call it the *yatra* effect. The Congress's Bharat Jodo Yatra had just about exited Karnataka this month when the ruling BJP set out on its 'Jana Sankalpa' rallies, with Chief Minister Basavaraj Bommai and party stalwart B.S. Yediyurappa (BSY) leading the charge in a counter-offensive to prepare the ground for state elections in May 2023. Anti-incumbency is a major worry, but the party is banking on a string of initiatives to woo the Dalit and Vokkaliga communities while trying to shrug off the opposition's corruption allegations with a tit-for-tat approach.

At Bommai's rallies in the third week of October in towns across the northern districts of Bidar, Gulbarga, Yadir and Raichur, the combative tone was evident when the CM raising the issue of recent arrests of 38 assistant high school teachers in the ongoing recruitment scam investigation. The Bommai government, which has been facing flak over irregularities in the recruitment of police sub-inspectors, is looking to divert attention to the alleged teachers' recruitment scam that had taken place under Congress watch. The CM also promised a probe into the decade-old Anwar Manippady committee report that had accused several Congress leaders of encroaching on Wakf properties allegedly worth some Rs 2 lakh crore.

AT BOMMAI'S RALLIES, THE PLAN IS TO SHRUG OFF THE OPPOSITION'S CORRUPTION ALLEGATIONS WITH A TIT-FOR-TAT APPROACH

The BJP sally comes even as the Congress has upped the corruption ante via poster campaigns with the catchphrase 'PayCM', which referenced allegations by a contractors' body that the Bommai-led government was charging 40 per cent commission on contracts for public works.

"The Congress is in an upbeat mood, you can't deny that," admits a BJP leader. But recent pro-active steps by the government such as increasing reservations for scheduled castes (from 15 per cent to 17 per cent) and scheduled tribes (from 3 per cent to 7 per cent) will strengthen the BJP's support base, he says.

At his rallies,